

Estate Planning in Plain English - Printable Worksheets

From *Estate Planning in Plain English: The 2027 Guide* by Daniel Marsh (Oro Enigma Publishing). Print as many copies as you need.

B1 - The inventory

What	Owner (me / spouse / joint / trust)	Institution and last 4 digits	Beneficiary or POD/TOD?	Approximate value	Cost basis (if known)
House					
Other real estate					
Checking account(s)					
Savings, CDs, money market					
Brokerage account(s)					
401(k) / 403(b) / TSP					
Traditional IRA(s)					

Roth IRA(s)					
Pension (survivor benefit?)					
Annuities					
Life insurance (death benefit)					
Business or partnership interest					
Vehicles, boat					
Valuables (jewellery, art, collections, tools)					
Digital assets (crypto, domains, channels, miles)					
Money owed to me					
Safe deposit box (where, who has access)					
Debts: mortgage /					

reverse mortgage					
Home equity line, car loans, cards, other					
Total assets / total debts / net estate					

B2 - The beneficiary audit

Account or policy	Primary beneficiary named	Contingent named	Right? (Y/N)	Fixed on	Confirmation kept?
401(k) / 403(b) / TSP					
Traditional IRA					
Roth IRA					
Life insurance policy 1					
Life insurance policy 2 / employer group life					
Annuity					
Pension survivor option					
Checking (POD added?)					
Savings / CDs (POD added?)					
Brokerage (TOD added?)					
Vehicle (TOD title, where allowed)					

House (joint / TOD deed / trust / will)					
529 plans (successor owner)					
HSA					

Rules to check against: no former spouse; no minor child named directly; no "my estate"; the spouse first and the children per stirpes as contingents; a special needs trust, not the child, for a disabled beneficiary; the charity on the traditional account.

B3 - The people

Role	First choice	Asked and agreed?	Successor	Asked?	Phone / email
Executor					
Financial agent (power of attorney)					
Health care agent (proxy)					
Guardian of minor children					
Guardian of the children's money (if					

different)					
Trustee (if a trust)					
Caretaker for pets					
Agent for disposition of remains					
Legacy contacts set (Google / Apple / Facebook)					
Lawyer					
Accountant / tax preparer					
Financial adviser					
Insurance agent					
The two people who know where the folder is					

B4 - The five-document checklist and the decisions

Document	Have it?	Signed on	State it was signed in	Where the original is	Who has copies
Will					
Durable financial power of attorney					
Health care power of attorney (proxy)					
Living will / advance directive					
HIPAA release					
Revocable trust (if any), and is it funded?					
Transfer-on-death deed (if any), recorded?					
Letter of instruction					

The decisions (write the answers before the lawyer's meeting):

Question	My answer
Everything to my spouse first? If not, what to whom?	
After both of us: equal shares to the children? Any exceptions, and why?	
If a child dies before me: to their children (per stirpes) or to the surviving children?	
Specific gifts (the house, the cabin, the ring, the tools, the piano): to whom?	
Charities, and how much or what percentage?	
At what age does a young beneficiary get control (25? 30? in stages?)	
Does anyone need a trust (disability, addiction, minor, second marriage, spendthrift)?	
Who gets the pets, and with how much?	
Who is left out on purpose (name	

them)?	
What happens to the business?	

B5 - The letter of instruction

Not a legal document; the note your family will actually use.
Keep it in the folder and update it every January.

Section	What to write
Where the documents are	Will, trust, powers, directive, deeds, titles, policies, tax returns: the folder, the lawyer, the box
The people to call first	Lawyer, executor, agents, doctor, employer, closest friends, clergy
The accounts	See the inventory (B1); note which bills are on autopay and from which account
The house	Mortgage or reverse mortgage details, insurance, alarm code, keys, who maintains what, where the shut-offs are
The wishes	Funeral (B7), who should have which personal things and why, the things that are not worth what people think, the things that are
The explanations	Why the shares are unequal, why someone is left out, why the trust exists, in your own words, without accusation
The digital life	See B6; where the master password is
The pets	Vet, food, medicines, habits, the person who agreed
The messages	Anything you want said to particular people

B6 - The digital list

Account /	What it is	Where	Value or	What to do	Legac
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device	(money, memories, subscription, identity)	the login is (password manager / note)	importance	(close / transfer / download / memorialise)	any contact set?
Phone passcode					
Computer login					
Email (primary)					
Password manager (master password location)					
Online banking / brokerage					
PayPal / Venmo / Cash App					
Cryptocurrency (exchange / wallet; seed phrase location)					
Google / Apple account (photos, files)					
Facebook / Instagram / X / LinkedIn					
YouTube / blog / domain					

names					
Airline miles, hotel points, store credit					
Subscription s (streaming, software, news, membership s)					
Two-factor codes: authenticator app / backup codes					
Other					

B7 - Funeral wishes

Question	My answer
Burial, cremation, green burial, or donation to science?	
Where (cemetery, plot owned?, scattering place, columbarium)?	
A service? Religious or not? Where? Who leads it?	
Music, readings, speakers	
Open or closed casket; what to wear; what to be buried or cremated with	
Flowers, or donations to (name the charity)	
Prepaid plan or funeral policy? With whom? Where are the papers?	
Veteran? Discharge papers (DD-214) location for burial benefits	
Who should write and place the obituary; what it	

should say and not say	
Who must be told personally, and by whom	
Agent for the disposition of remains (named in a form?)	
Budget, and where the money will come from before the estate is open	

B8 - The probate estimate

Item	Value	Goes through probate? (sole name, no beneficiary)	Could be moved outside probate by	Done?
House			joint title / TOD deed / trust	
Bank accounts			POD form	
Brokerage			TOD form	
Vehicles			TOD title (where allowed) / joint	

Personal property			will (small-estate affidavit if under the limit)	
Anything else in my sole name				
Total that would go through probate today				
My state's small-estate limit				
My state's typical probate cost (court fee + lawyer + executor) on that total				
My state's typical probate time				
Conclusion: arrange titles and forms / a trust is worth it / probate is fine				

B9 - Questions for the lawyer

Question	Answer
Is estate planning most of your practice? How many plans a year?	
What is the flat fee, and what does it include (deed, funding, follow-up, updates)?	
Do I need a trust, and why, in this state and for my family?	
What happens if my spouse remarries? If a child divorces? If a child dies before me?	
How should the retirement accounts be left, given the ten-year rule?	
Is my estate anywhere near the state tax threshold, and what would you do about it?	
Which of my assets should be retitled or given a beneficiary, and will you do it or	

tell me how?	
Should the power of attorney be immediate or springing, and what gift powers should it have?	
Will my bank accept your power of attorney form?	
What do I need for a disabled / addicted / estranged / minor beneficiary?	
What do you need from me before the meeting (the worksheets)?	
How often should we review, and what does an update cost?	
Who holds the originals, and how do my executor and agents get them?	
Do you do Medicaid planning, or who do you refer to?	

B10 - The review schedule

Review every three years, and at every event in the second table. Ten minutes with the checklist.

Check	Date	OK / to fix
The executor, agents, guardian and trustee: still alive, willing, able, right?		
Every beneficiary form (B2): still right? Contingents named?		
Titles and POD/TOD forms still match the plan? New accounts covered?		
The trust (if any) still funded: every new asset titled to it?		
The will still reflects the family: births, deaths, marriages, divorces, estrangements, reconciliations?		
The numbers in Appendix A: still under or over the state line?		
The folder: current inventory, current digital list, the two people know where it is?		

Legacy contacts still set? Password manager master password still where the note says?		
Powers of attorney less than five years old (banks prefer recent ones)?		

Event	Review what
Marriage or remarriage	Everything; the elective share; the beneficiary forms; a marital agreement
Divorce	Everything; beneficiary forms (many states revoke an ex-spouse automatically, but not on federal plans); the powers of attorney
A birth or adoption	Guardian; the will's definition of "children"; the contingent beneficiaries
A death in the family	The people; the shares; the beneficiary forms
A move to another state	The powers and the directive (state forms); the will's witnesses; the state tax; the TOD deed; community property
Retirement	The retirement-account beneficiaries; Roth conversions; the charity on the traditional account
A diagnosis	The powers and the directive now, while capacity is clear; Medicaid

	timing
A large inheritance, sale or windfall	The state tax line; a trust; gifts
A child's disability, addiction or bad marriage	A special needs or discretionary trust
Buying or selling real estate	Title; the TOD deed; the trust

